

Winter Palace

A magnificent Baroque palace that was once the St. Petersburg residence of the Russian czars



Built on the banks of the River Neva in the heart of St. Petersburg, the Winter Palace was designed by Italian architect Bartolomeo Rastrelli for Empress Elizabeth, who ruled Russia from 1741 to 1762. By the time the building was completed, the formidable Empress Catherine the Great (r.1762–1796) had taken the throne—she is the ruler with whom the palace is most associated.

Rastrelli created a vast three-story building with elongated facades. He decorated the interior in lavish Rococo style, although much of this work was destroyed by a disastrous fire in 1837. The palace was extended in the later years of Catherine's reign by the addition of the Hermitage wings.

From seat of power to museum

The imperial family continued using the palace until 1880, when the explosion of a bomb in the dining room showed it was too easy for would-be political assassins to penetrate. During the Russian Revolution of 1917, it was briefly the seat of a provisional government, which was driven out by the Bolsheviks in the storming of the palace. The Winter Palace is now the site of the Hermitage Museum, containing one of the world's foremost collections of painting and sculpture.

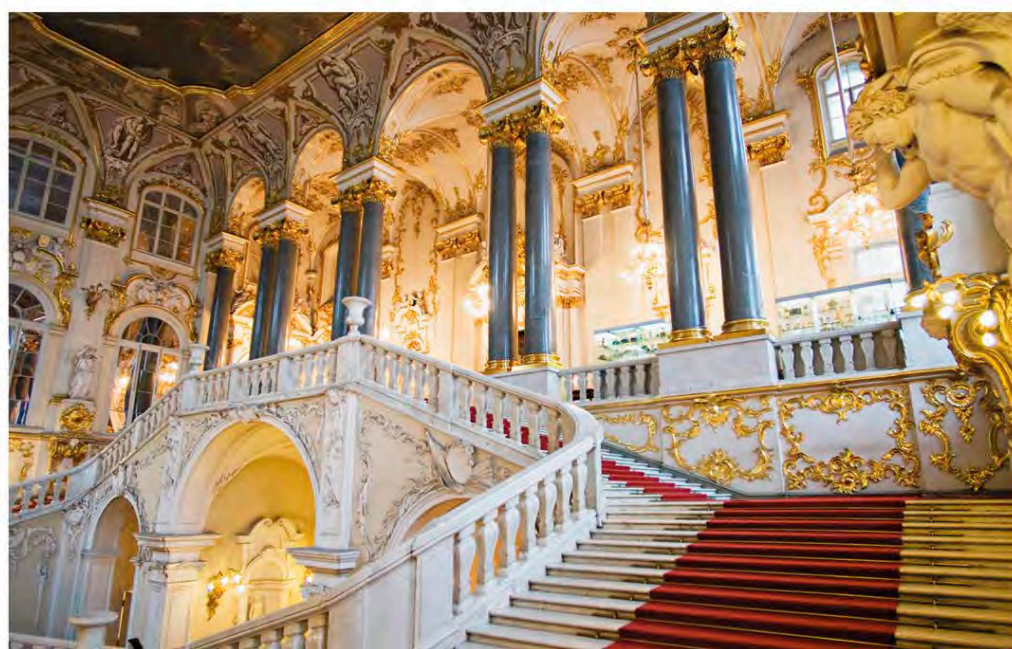


△ IMPERIAL EAGLE

The double-headed eagle was adopted as a symbol of Russian imperial power. This gilded version appears on one of the gates of the Winter Palace.

▽ ROCOCO STAIRS

The Jordan Staircase is one of the few elements of Rastrelli's original Rococo interior of the Winter Palace that has survived intact to the present day.



The Winter Palace contains **1,500 rooms and halls; 1,945 windows; and 117 staircases**



THE CATHEDRAL CRANE

When work on the cathedral halted in the 15th century, the builders left a crane on top of the unfinished southern steeple. A fine example of medieval engineering, the crane stayed on its lofty perch for 400 years. It was not dismantled until work on completing the steeple was finally resumed in 1868.

